

BOOK 1 OF THE HOLLOW DOMINION

THE DREAMING GATE

A D&D 5e Adventure for Levels 1-3

3-4 Sessions | 3-5 Players

by **Helm Evans**

Tuco Enterprises



ADVENTURE SUMMARY

A kingdom cursed by the death-throes of a dreaming god

BACKGROUND

The players are drawn to the Hollow Dominion by a shared dream — a vision of a dying god calling for help. Upon arrival, they discover the kingdom is cursed by the death-throes of **Mordath, the Dreaming God**. The landscape warps unpredictably, nightmare creatures stalk the roads, and the populace is divided between those fighting to survive and those who've given in to madness.

The players discover they are **Dreambound** — souls tethered to Mordath's fading consciousness, marked by a glowing sigil. They cannot leave until the curse is broken — and if Mordath dies without resolution, they die with him.

The adventure spans **three parts**: arrival at the Ashen Gate, investigation in the town of Drearym, and the climactic assault on the Gatehouse of Dreams.

ADVENTURE DETAILS		FACTIONS	
System	D&D 5e	Waking Guard	Soldiers maintaining order
Levels	1-3	Dreamseekers	Cultists seeking freedom
Sessions	3-4	Veil Court	Surviving nobility
Players	3-5	The Unbound	Nightmare-consumed victims
Tone	Dark fantasy mystery		

ADVENTURE HOOK: THE SHARED DREAM

"For three nights running, you've had the same dream. A vast chamber of white stone, a figure on a throne robed in starlight, its face hidden behind a mask of cracked porcelain. It speaks: 'Come. Please. Before it is too late.' On the fourth day, you each find a mark on your skin — a glowing sigil shaped like an eye within a crescent moon."

PART 1: THE ASHEN GATE

The entrance to the Hollow Dominion

DANGER ●●○○○

ARRIVAL

"The archway rises from the mist like a broken tooth. Once-grand stone, now cracked and leaking purple dream-energy that makes your sigil burn warm. Beyond the gate, trees grow sideways and the road shifts when you're not looking."

The Ashen Gate is the only known entrance. Passing through is one-way. Characters who touch the purple energy must make a **DC 12 WIS save** or experience a brief vision of Mordath's throne room.



Eldon Voss — The Gatekeeper, former captain of the Waking Guard

ENCOUNTER: ELDON VOSS, THE GATEKEEPER

"You're Dreambound. Welcome to the nightmare, friends. Mind the roads after dark. Things come through from the Dreaming Depths when the sun goes down."

- ◆ The Dominion has been cursed for **six months**
- ◆ The landscape warps unpredictably
- ◆ **Nightmare creatures** emerge at dusk
- ◆ The **Waking Guard** maintain order; the **Dreamseekers** want Mordath dead
- ◆ "Don't sleep near running water — that's where the nightmares come through strongest."

DM NOTE

Eldon was once a respected captain. The curse broke his mind but fragments of wisdom remain. Treat him with kindness and he's a valuable source of information.

THE TWISTED MARCH

Three days through nightmare-ravaged countryside

DANGER ●●●○○

RANDOM EVENTS (ROLL D8 EACH DAY)	
D8	EVENT
1	Shifting Path: DC 12 Survival or lose 1d4 hours + 1 exhaustion.
2	Dream Echo: One player sees Mordath before the curse. DC 13 WIS or 1 exhaustion.
3	Nightmare Wolf: Attacks from treeline. Flees at half HP.
4	Traveler: Refugee warns Dreamseekers are "harvesting" Dreambound.
5	Dream Shimmer: "Find the three keys." DC 14 WIS or 2d6 psychic.
6	Waking Guard Outpost: Safe rest, rations, information.
7	Thin Point: Purple pool. DC 13 CON or pulled into dream vision.
8	Peaceful Stretch: Clean water, mushrooms. Recover 1 exhaustion.

NIGHT ENCOUNTERS (ROLL D6)	
D6	ENCOUNTER
1-2	Nightmare Wolves: 1d4+1 attack the camp.
3-4	Dream Whispers: DC 12 WIS or no long rest, 1 exhaustion.
5	Unbound Patrol: 2 shamble past. Stealth DC 13.
6	Quiet Night: Distant purple glow — the Gatehouse.



Nightmare Wolf — Shadow-wolf touched by dream-energy, emerges at dusk

"The land remembers what it was. Sometimes, at the edges of your vision, you can see it — green fields, blue sky, children playing. Then you blink, and it's all twisted again."

MAP: THE TWISTED MARCH

Regional map — Ashen Gate to Drearym



The Twisted March — Forest clearing with purple pools marking thin points between worlds. Paths wind between camps and ruins.

LANDMARKS

- ◆ **Ashen Gate (South):** Entry point. Meet Eldon Voss.
- ◆ **Waking Guard Outpost:** Day 1. Safe haven with supplies.
- ◆ **The Wellspring:** Day 1-2. Ancient well leaking purple energy. Side quest: rescue Lissa Greel.
- ◆ **Ruined Tower of Valdris:** Day 2. DC 14 Investigation finds hidden journal page.
- ◆ **Purple Pools:** Thin points between worlds. Nightmare creatures emerge after dark.
- ◆ **Drearym (North):** Day 3. First major town. Faction tensions.

PART 2: THE TOWN OF DREARYM

A town on the edge of collapse

DANGER ●●●○○

ARRIVAL

"Drearym was once a prosperous market town of 2,000. Now it holds perhaps 800. A makeshift wall of sharpened logs surrounds the town. Purple mist hovers in the alleys. Some buildings lean at impossible angles."

KEY LOCATIONS

A. The Vigorous Dog (Inn) — Run by **Marta Greel**, former adventurer. Her daughter **Lissa** went missing. **50gp reward**.

B. Waking Guard Barracks — **Captain Rena Ashford**. Investigate nightmare sightings (**30gp reward**). Warns about Brother Caelum.

C. Old Town Chapel — **Dreamseekers** led by **Brother Caelum**. He preaches that Mordath's death will "free" the Dreambound. Being manipulated by The Architect.

D. Market Square — Notice board with missing persons, bounties, Dreamseeker recruitment.

E. The Wellspring — Outside eastern wall. Purple dream-energy. Lissa's last known location. Dangerous at night.

F. North Gate — Waking Guard checkpoint. Curfew after sunset.

FACTION: THE DREAMSEEKERS

The Dreamseekers believe killing Mordath will end the curse. They're **wrong** — it will kill every Dreambound. **The Truth:** Caelum is being manipulated by **The Architect** — an entity within Mordath's dreams that wants the god dead.

MAP: DREARYM

Town map — Key locations and faction territories



Drearym — A walled market town under siege. Purple water flows through the settlement. Letters mark key locations.

LOCATION KEY	
◆ A — The Vigorous Dog: Marta's inn. Safe haven. 5sp/night.	◆ D — Market Square: Notice board. Refugee camp.
◆ B — Waking Guard Barracks: Captain Ashford's HQ. 12 Guards.	◆ E — The Wellspring: Outside east wall. Lissa's location.
◆ C — Old Town Chapel: Dreamseeker meeting place. Secret basement.	◆ F — North Gate: Guard checkpoint. Curfew after dark.

MAJOR NPCs

The god, the captain, and the priest



Mordath — The Dreaming God, his divine form crumbling, leaking dream-energy into the mortal world



Captain Rena Ashford — Commander of the Waking Guard, holding Drearym together by sheer will



Brother Caelum — Dreamseeker priest, charismatic but being manipulated by The Architect



Marta Greel — Innkeeper of The Vigorous Dog, former adventurer, mother of missing Lissa

MARTA GREEL & THE DREAMING WELL

The innkeeper and the missing girl

MARTA GREEL — INNKEEPER

MEDIUM HUMANOID (HUMAN), CHAOTIC GOOD

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
14	10	16	12	13	11
+2	+0	+3	+1	+2	+0

AC 12 | HP 27 (5d8+5) | Speed 20 ft. (peg leg)

Skills: Intimidation +2, Medicine +3, Survival +4

Equipment: Hand crossbow (+4, 1d6 piercing), peg leg (improvised, +4, 1d4+2)

Personality: Blunt, practical, fiercely protective. Lost her leg to a Nightmare Spawn. Lost her husband to the Unbound. Lissa is all she has left.

ENCOUNTER: THE DREAMING WELL

The Wellspring is a thin point between worlds. **Lissa Greel** sits at the well's edge, trapped in a Dream Loop. **2 Nightmare Spawn** guard the well. Within 10ft = difficult terrain. Within 5ft = DC 12 WIS or pulled toward well.

Option 1 — Physical Pull: DC 14 STR. DC 13 WIS or stunned if failed.

Option 2 — Enter the Dream: DC 13 WIS to enter. DC 13 Persuasion to convince Lissa. Failure = 2d6 psychic.

Option 3 — Disrupt: DC 14 Arcana. Success = Spawn take 3d6 radiant. Failure = 2d6 psychic.

NIGHTMARE SPAWN (RESKINNED SHADOW)

MEDIUM UNDEAD, CHAOTIC EVIL

AC 12 | HP 16 (3d8+3) | Speed 40 ft.

Strength Drain. +4 to hit, 2d6+2 **psychic** damage. Target's STR reduced by 1d4. STR 0 = death, rises as Unbound in 1d4 rounds.

Nightmare Aura: Within 10ft, DC 11 WIS or frightened.

Dream Vulnerability: +1d6 radiant from moonlight effects.

Amorphous, Shadow Stealth (Hide as bonus in dim light)

PART 3: THE GATEHOUSE OF DREAMS

The boundary between worlds

DANGER ●●●●○



The Gatehouse of Dreams — Ancient monastery built into the cliff, now consumed by dream-energy

THE FOUR WINGS

- ◆ **Dormitory (West):** DC 13 Investigation finds journal page about Mordath's prophecy.
- ◆ **Library (North):** Lore — Mordath foresaw his own death. The Architect is his fear given sentience.
- ◆ **Chapel (East):** 3 Nightmare Spawn. DC 13 WIS or vision of Mordath pleading.
- ◆ **Gate Hall (South):** The Dreaming Gate — massive purple portal to Mordath's throne room.

THE GATE HALL — APPROACHING THE PORTAL

"The Gate Hall opens onto the cliff edge. Before you stands the Dreaming Gate — thirty feet tall, filled with swirling purple energy. Through the portal: a white throne room. On the throne sits a figure robed in starlight, mask of cracked porcelain. Dying."

Between you and the portal stands a figure in purple armor, twin blades of crackling pink energy. It does not speak. But you feel its sorrow.

BOSS: THE NIGHTMARE KNIGHT

Guardian of the Dreaming Gate

DANGER ●●●●●●



The Nightmare Knight — A Dreambound soul guarding the gate, wields twin energy blades of crackling pink lightning

THE GUARDIAN

The Nightmare Knight is a **Dreambound soul** — not evil, merely bound by duty. **Social:** DC 15 Persuasion (DC 12 if Lissa rescued). Success: "The god is dying. What you do in there will determine whether the Dominion lives or dies." **Combat:** Hard for level 3. Surrenders at 20 HP.

NIGHTMARE KNIGHT

MEDIUM UNDEAD, LAWFUL NEUTRAL

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
18	14	18	12	14	16
+4	+2	+4	+1	+2	+3

AC 15 | **HP** 85 (10d8+40) | **Speed** 30 ft.
Resist: Necrotic, B/P/S nonmagical | **Vuln:** Radiant | **Immune:** Charmed, Exhaustion, Frightened, Poisoned
Multiattack. Two Energy Blades. *Energy Blade.* +7, 2d6+4 slashing + 1d8 psychic.
Life Drain (Recharge 5-6). +7, 3d6+4 psychic, heals half. *Dream Step (Bonus).* Teleport 30ft.
Parry (Reaction). +3 AC vs one melee. **Legendary (1/round):** *Reposition.* Move 15ft.

TOUCHING THE GATE

"The world dissolves into white. Three keys. Find them. The Architect wears my fear like a crown. The Crown lies in the Fractured Court. The Heart beats in the Dreaming Depths. Please. I cannot hold on much longer."
Each character gains **Dreamsense** (30ft, always active) and visions of Books 2-5 locations.

END OF BOOK 1

Return to Drearym — and a cliffhanger for Book 2

RESOLUTION

- ◆ Mordath is dying — not trying to harm anyone.
- ◆ There are **three keys**: The Architect, The Crown, The Heart.
- ◆ The Architect — a fragment of Mordath's own fear — wants the god dead.
- ◆ Brother Caelum and the Dreamseekers are being manipulated.
- ◆ The players are Dreambound — tied to Mordath's fate.

CLIFFHANGER FOR BOOK 2

"As you leave the Gatehouse, you see them. A vast army of Unbound — hundreds strong — marching toward Drearym. At their head: Brother Caelum, eyes glowing purple. He's been converting Dreambound into Unbound, building an army to storm the Fractured Court and kill Mordath by force."

TREASURE & REWARDS

Guardian's Longsword (uncommon, attunement)
+1 longsword. Extra 1d4 psychic vs undead/fiends. 1/day: *detect thoughts* (DC 13).

Marta's Gratitude
If Lissa rescued: *Potion of Greater Healing* + *Cloak of Elvenkind*. Free lodging.

Monastery Journal
25gp value. DC 15 History reveals Fractured Court location (Book 2).

Milestone: Party reaches level 3.

GM NOTES

Tone: Waking up in someone else's nightmare. Mordath is not a villain — he's a dying god.

Scaling: Level 1: Knight HP 60, no Legendary Actions. Level 4+: +2 Nightmare Spawn, Knight +10 HP.

THE HOLLOW DOMINION

A once-prosperous kingdom cursed by the death-throes of Mordath, the Dreaming God. His nightmares leak into the waking world — twisting landscapes, corrupting creatures, and driving the populace mad.

The players are Dreambound — souls tethered to Mordath's fading consciousness. They cannot leave until the curse is broken. But if Mordath dies, they die with him.

From the Ashen Gate to the Gatehouse of Dreams, the party must navigate nightmare-ravaged lands, choose which faction to trust, and find the three keys that can save the Dominion — or doom it forever.

D&D 5e | Levels 1-3 | 3-4 Sessions | 3-5 Players

by Helm Evans

Tuco Enterprises